

Episode 184: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 11

Before I knew it, it's already June, and the new programmes that started in April have mostly passed 10 episodes, with one-cour shows already at their climax. *Saint Seiya Omega* that I'm participating in is planned as a one-year series. We've finally passed the first major climax of the early part. The story will steadily progress toward the next climax from here.

Among those who have been watching since the original series, I think some might be puzzled by how different it is from the original *Saint Seiya*, but this is the new *Saint Seiya*. I hope you'll enjoy the new characters and their stories created by new staff at a new tempo. I'm also going "Ah, I see! (laugh)" with daily admiration while contributing lots of ideas and enjoying making it together. It's quite tough though (laugh).

Such *Saint Seiya Omega* - please support us, everyone!

Now then.

Episode 9: The Ice World Storyboard, Direction & Animation Director/Takeuchi Nobuyuki (武内宣之), Colour Direction/Tsujita Kunio

Just when Ringo and Shoma were lamenting each other's heart shadows on the rain-soaked emergency stairs at Tabuki's apartment, at the Takakura house Himari was vaguely experiencing a mysterious space. The Sky Hole Branch of the library. In those deep layers of heart and memory underground, Himari meets Mario (真惻). Confronting "that time" within memories of her own origins, Himari. And the faint memory she reached was a place with an ominous atmosphere called "Children's Broiler." Such was Episode 9.

Episode 9 was truly Takeuchi Nobuyuki in full force! Storyboard, almost all rough animation, animation director, and direction. This Episode 9, which took time carefully

and deliberately, required about 3 months of actual work. Completion slightly overran one week before broadcast.

The main stage, the "Sky Hole Branch," was entirely constructed in 3D from layout onward. Takeuchi went to art director Akiyama's Studio Pablo, learning to use 3D tools while building it together with Akiyama. Bookshelves extending endlessly couldn't be drawn by hand, and rather, by assembling them with 3D layout, they injected clear "discomfort" compared to the screen atmosphere up to Episode 8, creating screens that were orderly yet somehow anxious.

With various devices applied in background art, I didn't do anything tricky in colour design, dedicating myself entirely to creating colour tones to match the brightness of the art space. However, Himari's flashback scenes interspersed between the matter-of-fact cold library scenes were sometimes afternoon sunlight, sometimes incandescent lighting - I tried to bracket them with colour tones that felt yellow somewhere. While this was also aimed as contrast with the library scenes' colour tone, I wonder if I successfully expressed the languidness of memories that aren't necessarily pleasant?

Photography for Episode 9 was by Sanzigen. Yamada and Uezono from Sanzigen's photography department, which had just been established. We had planned from the beginning to irregularly request the OP and this Episode 9, well, with schedule considerations. But when we opened the lid it was quite difficult (wry laugh). The total cut count was nearly 400 (normal 30-minute shows are around 300 cuts), with not a few special processes and things that had to be assembled in 3D. And the book spine paste-ins for that library were all pasted in by photography.

This paste-in work became incredibly difficult, and actually those book titles are all different! The "Frog-kun" series in particular was moving (laugh).

So those library book paste-ins, the 3D floor rotating and disappearing - they would reappear in different forms in Episode 13 and the final episode.

Now, Episode 9 was Mario's debut episode.

Right around the time we were producing Episode 9, we were making the OP, and actually Mario's character wasn't completed yet. We had Hoshino's character rough draft and Nishii's rough character setting, and layout work proceeded based on those, but Mario's final character setting, including colouring, was decided to meet the OP work deadline (we proceeded with colour decisions using rough settings), resulting in simultaneous work.

For Mario's colour image, I initially had a "pure white" image and thought "how about a character that's pure white from top to bottom?" Hair and even eyelashes white. And red pupils. That kind of image. But when I secretly tried it, white eyelashes felt like too much of an overdo (laugh), so I adjusted to a more human-like colour tone and showed it to the director.

"Hmm..." the director said, but seemed to have a somewhat lukewarm impression. Somehow the response felt unclear. While my Mario had come together atmospherically, it certainly felt lacking in the impact and assertiveness that the character "Mario" should have. But I made this the "provisional final version" and began preparing for temporary colouring work. That was June 13th. While proceeding with work, I reconsidered the colours. What was lacking in this model? And what emerged was that pink-haired Mario.

"Well, I guess it would end up like this after all..." said the director. Thus Mario was solidified. It was the night of June 23rd (laugh). With less than a month until Episode 1 broadcast, it was truly the last minute for opening work.

So the opening was fine, but the problem was Episode 9 - actually, for Mario's first appearance, his costume was library staff costume (laugh). So this also required urgent correction.

Mario was decided through all these various processes. While we knew he was an important key in the story, at the time we were producing Episode 9, how the story would end and what exactly Mario's true identity was remained far in the fog, in the director's mind.

Now, this Episode 9 has differences between the broadcast version and Blu-ray/DVD version. It's the deepest part of the Sky Hole Branch, the scene with Mario and Princess of the Crystal.

When first made, we had coloured Himari's pupils in Princess costume with the usual pink, but that really bothered me. The reason being that we had established the symbol pupil→pink when controlled by the hat, but in this scene, while Himari is wearing Princess costume, she's not actually being controlled, is she? So I consulted with Director Ikuhara.

"Hmm, that might be so. But well, either way..."

The decision was left to me, so in the Blu-ray/DVD version, I corrected the pink pupils to Himari's normal coloured pupils (though there are cuts intentionally left pink). So for those doing detailed analysis, I planted further "seeds" (laugh).

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